

Sociology (Five Topics)

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Section 1 of 100:09:58 Hide Timer

Your professor is teaching a class on sociology. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

Let's think about population trends in urban and rural areas (villages). Living in urban areas can be expensive; nonetheless, when they have a choice of where to live, people in some countries do not wish to live in rural areas even if the cost of living there is lower. If governments of some countries want to attract more people to live in rural areas or villages, what is the best strategy or approach that governments can use? Why?



Claire

I would live in a rural area if the government gave more financial help to farmers. Although it may cost very little to live in a rural area, it costs a lot to begin a career in agriculture. If I had financial help, I would start my own farm and be happy to live in a rural area.



Kelly

In my country, urban centers are great places to live because you can access shops, restaurants, and museums. If the government of my country wanted to attract me to live in a rural area, the area would first have to attract more businesses focused on entertainment and culture than most rural areas have now.

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Section 1 of 100:09:59 Hide Timer

Your professor is teaching a class on public policy. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Gupta

This week, we will be discussing a shortage of affordable housing that exists in many countries. In these places, housing—both apartments (flats) and houses—are expensive, because populations are growing faster than new housing is being built. Now, think about places in your country that have a housing shortage. In your post, I would like you to indicate the most effective way for the government to address a housing shortage in your country. Please explain why you think so.



Claire

In my country, there is a lack of affordable housing in the big cities. Low-cost housing exists in areas outside of the cities, but that means workers have long commutes to reach their jobs in the cities. I recommend that my government create initiatives to encourage the construction of large buildings with many affordable apartments in cities.



Paul

Claire's recommendation is fine, but many people prefer to live in a house rather than an apartment, even if they have longer commutes. Living in a house can be quieter and more private. So, I believe my government should give subsidies or tax relief to construction companies to build small, affordable single-family houses on unused land that surrounds many cities.

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Diaz

In our class this week, we are going to talk about the importance of friendship to each individual. As we all know, humans are social creatures. Making new friends can be difficult in certain circumstances, but there are many successful ways to make friends, of course. What do you think is the best way to make new friends and why do you think so?



Kelly

Volunteering is a good way to make new friends. Recently our city's Beautification Committee asked for volunteers to plant flowers around the downtown square, to make it more appealing for residents and visitors. I joined a dozen others in that activity. While we worked, we had the opportunity to talk and get to know each other.



Paul

I have made a few good friends by taking a class at the local library. It was a class in stamp collecting, and I met some very interesting people. The key is to stay in touch after the class is over, do additional activities together, and make an effort to build a friendship. We just had lunch together today.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:52 Hide Time

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Gupta

When people are choosing a career, there are many different factors to consider. What aspects of a job do people value most? Salary is a possible factor. These days, with work environments evolving, human interaction might be an important factor. If you had to choose, is it better to have a job with a high salary but little or no human interaction, or a job with a lower salary that allows for regular interaction with colleagues or customers? Why?



Paul

In order for people to be truly satisfied with a job they need validation. This can only come from frequent and productive interaction with coworkers who acknowledge their hard work and contributions. I think everyone is looking for a job where they will receive positive feedback from their colleagues and recognition for their achievements.



Kelly

I think that salary is the number one factor in determining whether a certain job is good or not. In any job interview, the first question many of us, including myself, really want answered is how much the job pays. Being a practical person, I would say the purpose of work is to earn money, not to socialize with others.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:53 Hide Time

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Dr. Diaz

This week, we discussed the importance of role models and opinion makers in society. One idea we discussed was the widespread impact of "influencers." Influencers are people who are very active posting on social media and who have many followers. Influencers' posts and opinions can influence their followers' choices on everything from fashion to politics. In your opinion, do social media influencers generally have a positive or negative effect on their followers? Why do you think so?



Kelly

I think the influencers' effect is generally positive. People can learn about the latest trends and topics in a very quick and efficient way by following influencers. In the past, people had to spend time looking through magazines or visiting boutiques to even know what was trending.



Paul

I think influencers generally have a negative effect because they have far too much influence. I can think of one influencer who only has to mention a particular kind of sports shoe, and the next day they'll be sold out. The followers aren't really thinking for themselves; they're just blindly following the influencers' choices.

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Education (Ten Articles)

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Your professor is teaching a class on education. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

Companies now make computer games designed to help very young children learn. The games are advertised for use by children aged 2 to 8 years and often involve basic math and reading skills, presented in a fun, game-like style. Some people say that this results in children spending too much time looking at computer screens. Do you think it's a good idea for very young children to play educational computer games? Why or why not?



Andrew

I think it's completely inappropriate for children as young as 2 years old to play what are essentially video games. Even if the games are educational, the same skills can be taught in traditional ways—by reading books to children, for example. And it would be beneficial to interact with their parents in this way.



Kelly

Considering how important computers are to human societies these days, I think it actually makes sense to allow very young children to explore them. And if the computer games that children play also give them early access to subject matter that will later be taught in school, all the better.

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00:09:58 Hide Timer

Your professor is teaching a class on education. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

This week, we'll look at how well students transition to university. Many recent high school graduates have taken a gap year—a yearlong break after graduation—before studying at a university. During a gap year, students may get jobs, travel, or simply relax and think about their future. Some students say their gap year was beneficial, while others regret having taken one. In your opinion, does taking a gap year create more advantages or disadvantages for students? Why?



Andrew

The gap year would be a good opportunity for students to reflect on their education goals and confirm their plans for university. At least it would give someone time to investigate different fields and get a better sense of what it means to be in business, to work in an office, or to work with their hands, etc.



Claire

Because university can be expensive, students should not take a gap year. Tuition, the cost of books, and living expenses rise every year. The money a student might save during a gap year might not be enough to cover the rise in prices when they enter university a year later.

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Section 1 of 1

00:09:59 Hide Timer

Your professor is teaching a class on educational administration. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Diaz

Teachers often ask school administrators for permission to take their students on field trips (for example, to museums or historical buildings). Some school administrators provide funding and encouragement for teachers to organize educational trips for the entire class. Many believe that going on field trips is an important part of a child's education; others think that a child's time is better spent learning in a classroom at school. Which view do you agree with? Why?



Kelly

Field trips are so demanding of a teacher's time; I can understand why some people aren't in favor of them. Teachers can't just decide that it might be fun to take their class to an art museum. They must plan carefully to help children get the most out of that trip while not losing too much instructional time.



Paul

Field trips can affect kids' futures in important ways. One time I went on a field trip to a space museum when I was young. I even got to try on a space suit. That experience made me want to be an astronomer. I might not have developed my interest in astronomy without that field trip experience.

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00:09:54 Hide Time

Write a post responding to the professor's question.

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Dr. Achebe

This week, we'll examine issues in education reform. For example, some educators think that by focusing mainly on foundational knowledge in subjects like reading, math, and science, schools are not fully preparing students for success in the workplace. These educators argue that soft skills—nonacademic skills such as being empathetic or having a strong work ethic—should be part of the curriculum, with classroom time dedicated to developing these skills. Do you agree? Why or why not?



Claire

I agree. While students need a strong foundation in academic subjects, soft skills are important because they affect how well students do their work. If classroom time is set aside for these skills, students will take them seriously and their academic work will benefit. Teachers could design lessons so that students learn about a skill and then do role-playing activities with classmates.



Andrew

Soft skills are important, but I don't agree with using classroom time to work on them. I'm not sure how teachers would measure students' progress in developing these skills. If students' progress can't be measured on something being taught, I'm not sure if there's any point to teaching it.

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Your professor is teaching a class on education. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

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Doctor Gupta

Let's discuss how teachers' job performance is assessed or evaluated. Regular evaluations of teachers help to ensure that students receive high-quality instruction, that good teachers are rewarded, and that struggling teachers receive help to improve. But what is the best way to evaluate teachers? Should teachers be evaluated based on their students' test scores? Should more-experienced teachers evaluate less-experienced teachers? Should students' feedback



Andrew

I think experienced senior teachers are the best source of information for teacher evaluations. School leaders can assign experienced teachers to observe their fellow teachers periodically during class, and these senior teachers can then provide feedback on their colleagues' performance. An experienced teacher has the knowledge to determine what other teachers are doing well and what needs improvement.



Kelly

I'm not convinced that any one person's occasional visits to a classroom would provide accurate information. I'd like a more objective, fairer source of data, so I'd prefer to rely on test scores to inform teacher evaluations. If all students take the same test, and some classes perform better than others, then we know which teachers have been most successful.

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Doctor Gupta

This week, I want you to discuss assessment criteria. Some schoolteachers give high grades (marks) only to those students who perform well on their homework assignments and tests. Other teachers, however, may give high grades to students who have worked very hard on their assignments but have not performed so well. Which approach do you think is better: Giving grades based only on performance, or grading students not just on performance but also on their effort?



Kelly

I think grades should be based on performance only. It's a matter of fairness. I'd be really upset if another student got nearly the same grade that I did when I turned in work that was almost perfect and the other student's work had incorrect answers or unclear ideas. It wouldn't matter to me if they worked harder.



Paul

Sure, evaluation should mainly be based upon the student's performance, but hard work should count for something. A student who works hard, even when the final grade isn't the highest in the class, builds character, which will benefit the student later in life when they go to university or apply for a job.

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Dr. Diaz

This week we will discuss issues faced by secondary school administrators. I'm referring to schools for teenage students. One such issue is students who change schools. Students change schools for many different reasons, the most common being a family move. On the discussion board, I want you to exchange ideas about what schools can do to make the transition to a new school easier for teenagers.



Paul

I think schools should assign new students a fellow student who can help them adjust. The "student buddy" can do things like make sure the new student can find the cafeteria or the right classrooms. For new students, it's a lot easier to ask a fellow student a question rather than ask a teacher or the principal.



Claire

I would require new students to sign up for some school club or activity that meets outside of class. That way, new students would have an easy way to meet other students in a friendly environment. It would give them a group to immediately identify with.

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Dr. Gupta

This week, we'll be discussing ways in which schools can help expose their students (aged 5–18) to learning experiences beyond the classroom. Let's begin by discussing one popular idea that some schools are considering—offering outdoor classes once a month. On the day of outdoor classes, students will be transported to local parks or nature preserves, and teachers can help students explore nature and learn about the environment. Do you think this is a good idea?



Kelly

Having outdoor classes once a month seems like an exciting way of providing students with interesting hands-on experiences. However, I don't think these classes would be a worthwhile use of instructional time and of school resources. These classes could put substantial pressure on schools' financial resources and on teachers, who may have to redesign their lesson plans.



Paul

Outdoor classes can increase students' motivation for learning about interconnectedness in the natural world. These classes could be great opportunities to teach students about dire environmental problems, such as pollution, and ways of addressing these problems. It will deepen their understanding beyond what books could do and would be time well spent.

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Offering outdoor classes once a month is a wonderful idea. Exploring nature opens

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00:08:27 Hide Time

your professor is teaching a class on educational philosophy. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Diaz

What should children be learning in school? Many people believe that time in the classroom should be spent acquiring foundational knowledge in subjects like math, reading, science, and history. Others feel that it's important for a child's creativity to be nurtured, and thus the school curriculum must include classes in art and music. There's so much to learn, yet so little time in school to learn it all! What do you think should be included in the curriculum? Why?



Claire

I agree that traditional subjects like math, science, and reading are important, but so are classes in art and music. Engaging with art and music can help children be more creative and can stimulate their imaginations. That in turn facilitates critical thinking, which is essential in any curriculum, so I am in favor of including art and music in the school day.



Paul

Sure, drawing pictures and listening to music is fun, but children can do that on their own time. The school day is too short as it is, and there is so much foundational knowledge in math, reading, science, and history that children need to learn; it is better to spend classroom time on that foundational knowledge and let kids explore art and music at home.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:41 Hide Time

policy. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

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Dr. Achebe

We will soon be discussing issues related to high school educational requirements. In many countries, there are core (central) study subjects that all high school students are required to take and pass in order to graduate. These requirements are fundamental to any curriculum—they express beliefs about which academic subjects should be prioritized. Where do you stand? If you had to choose, what one academic subject do you think is most important for today's high school students? Explain your choice.



Claire

I think the most important subject for secondary students is math, and I think the absolute minimum level for graduation should be algebra. Math is critical for adult life, from personal finance to basic home repair. I feel like modern technology has degraded people's basic math skills and made them too dependent on apps and machines to accomplish tasks.



Andrew

The one class that all students in high school should take and pass is biology. Understanding basic biology will not only give them a good background in general science, but it could also help them keep their own bodies healthy. For example, everyone should have some understanding of what effects medications have if there is a need to take them.

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Parenting (Three Articles)

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:58 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on childhood development. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

Dr. Gupta

This week we covered different parenting styles. One idea we discussed was how much independence and freedom we should give our children, especially young children. One related issue is whether there should be an age limit on when children can have mobile phones. In this discussion post, I would like you to discuss whether you agree or disagree with the idea of setting a minimum age for when children can have a mobile phone. Explain your opinion.

Andrew

I totally agree with the idea of not giving children phones before they reach a certain age, let's say ten years or so. I believe children younger than ten are not yet ready to deal with the world that comes with mobile phones, as it can put them in harm's way.

Claire

Honestly, I am against the idea of restricting mobile phone access for young children. I believe mobile phones can help children communicate with their parents if they need their help for an urgent matter when they are away from their parents at school or elsewhere. Maybe companies can invent a special kind of mobile phone that is somehow kid friendly.

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Your professor is teaching a class on child development. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

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- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

Doctor Diaz

We've been discussing ways that parents can help prepare their teenage children for adulthood. One line of thinking is that parents should encourage their teenagers to take part-time jobs to help them learn to be responsible, even if it is not an economic necessity for the teenagers to work. What are your thoughts on the issue? Should parents urge teenage children to get a job? Why or why not?

Claire

Teenagers should work part-time. When I was 16, I washed dishes at a restaurant, and I'm glad I did. I learned a lot about time management. I had to use my free time wisely to make sure I could complete homework despite spending time working at a job. This is a valuable life skill.

Andrew

I would have to disagree. A teenager is still just a kid, and in my opinion, a kid needs to focus on going to school and learning. A job would be an unnecessary distraction. If it's all about learning responsibility, I think there are a lot of other ways to do that without the commitment required by a job.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:59 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on education. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Diaz

Some educators think that in our global, tech-oriented world, students need to focus on nonfiction texts, such as news stories, technical manuals, or other informational materials. They say that reading poetry, novels, and short stories is not the optimal use of the limited time that students have in the classroom. How do you view this approach to education? Should schools limit the teaching of fictional texts in favor of teaching more practical, nonfiction texts?



Andrew

Education has to evolve. Nowadays, there's an enormous amount of economic and political data freely available online. It's important that students can evaluate this information to understand local and world events in order to be good citizens. Reading fiction is a wonderful hobby, but school should prepare students for adult life and its responsibilities.



Claire

I spent a lot of class time in high school analyzing literature. I'm studying to be an engineer, so I admit that reading fiction in school was not directly applicable to my future occupation, but it did instill in me a love of reading, which is very valuable. I feel better equipped now to understand all sorts of written material.

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Environment (Five Articles)

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Section 1 of 1

00:09:58 Hide Timer

Your professor is teaching a class on environmental science. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

In our textbook, we read that parks and other green spaces with trees and plants have numerous benefits for people in cities. But city governments sometimes must choose between using a piece of available land as a green space or using it for other important purposes, such as for shopping areas or for manufacturing plants. In your opinion, which is the better use for available urban space? Why?



Kelly

It's true that parks can benefit people in cities, especially health-wise. But it's more important to use the limited space for things that people cannot survive without, like hospitals or clinics. Medical care is often an urgent necessity. Visiting a park is not.



Claire

I'm all for creating green spaces for people to enjoy, but you don't necessarily need an open piece of land to do that. Let the available land be used for business or housing purposes. Green spaces can be created on the rooftops of existing buildings. And new buildings can be constructed creatively to include open spaces with plants and trees.

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Section 1 of 1

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Your professor is teaching a class on environmental science. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Diaz

Nowadays, the world is facing a number of pressing environmental problems, and over the next few weeks, we'll be discussing various innovations that may help solve these problems. To begin our discussion, I'd like you to think of one global environmental problem—for example, it could be related to water, air, land, climate, biodiversity, energy, or something similar. Then explain what you think would be an effective solution to this problem.



Kelly

One of the major environmental problems is the limited freshwater supply in many areas of the world, which means that we need to find effective technologies to provide people with enough drinking water. One solution is to improve the technology for removing salt from seawater, which could allow us to use seawater to replenish dwindling freshwater supplies.



Paul

I think the biggest problem is the air pollution caused by the overuse of motorized vehicles. The obvious solution is for local governments to promote alternatives, like building bike lanes in cities or improving public transportation with electric buses. Both of these would be easy to implement as well.

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Writing

Question 2 of 2

00:09:53

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Your professor is teaching a class on environmental science. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

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- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Achebe

This week, we'll be discussing ways to address air pollution. One idea is introducing environmental taxes on air travel. Such taxes, also referred to as ecological taxes or green taxes, are extra charges that get added to the price of airplane tickets. Money collected from these taxes could be invested in environmentally friendly technologies or in promoting other, cleaner modes of transportation. Do you think there should be an environmental tax on air travel? Why or why not?

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Andrew

We should impose environmental taxes on air travel. These taxes might encourage people to find cheaper, more eco-friendly ways to get places. In my country, many people use planes to fly a short distance because flights are relatively cheap, when they could just as easily take a less polluting form of transportation.

Claire

Additional taxes on air travel will do little to solve the problem of air pollution. Airplane tickets would become more expensive, punishing passengers without incentivizing airlines to become more environmentally friendly. The airlines should pay the price to protect the environment, not their customers.

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Writing

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00:09:17

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- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Achebe

This week in class, we are discussing how concern about the environment is affecting consumer behavior. One recent trend in some countries is that consumers are trying to reuse products and materials as much as possible; for example, by buying used clothing or a used car instead of a new one. In your posts, I want you to discuss either an advantage or a disadvantage of buying used or recycled products as opposed to new ones.

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Andrew

Besides the benefits to the environment, one advantage is that many vintage, previously owned products have more charm. For example, old furniture has a lot of character and history, and it always makes a room more interesting. People can even make furniture from reclaimed materials, like making a table from an old wooden door, which always looks unique.

Kelly

Buying used products has its drawbacks. New products are backed by the company that made them. If you buy a new washing machine and it does not work properly, the company will replace or repair it. If you buy something used and it breaks, it's your responsibility to fix it, and the parts are not always available.

Economics (Six Articles)

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Your professor is teaching a class on economics. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

In 1930, a famous economist predicted that at the end of the twentieth century, an average worker would work only 15 hours a week, thanks to advances in technology. This did not happen, as we all know. Nonetheless, the balance between work time and free time remains an interesting question. So, let me ask you today: Twenty years in the future, will people have more leisure time (free time) and less work than they have today? Why, or why not?



Claire

I think it is likely that people will work shorter hours in twenty years than they do today. Our societies are becoming wealthier all the time. It does not seem necessary for people to continue working as hard as they do today. At some point, having more free time should be more important than creating more wealth.



Paul

I am not sure people will work less in the future. As Doctor Achebe wrote, a shortening of the workweek was predicted before. There are many factors that determine how long people work. Our economic system is very competitive. Workers are pushed to work longer and longer hours so that companies have a competitive advantage.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:52 Hide Time

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

Dr. Achebe

In class this week, we are looking at how markets work, particularly in regard to energy costs. Petroleum, also known simply as oil, is one of the most important international commodities. When the global market price of oil goes up, fuels such as gasoline (petrol) also become more expensive. Many people think governments should step in to protect consumers from increases in fuel prices. What is your view? Do you think governments should actively keep fuel prices low for

Kelly

I think it's a good government policy. Most people have to drive or use public transportation, like a bus, to get to work. When the price of gasoline goes up, it costs them more to get to work. People don't have a choice about whether to go to work or not, so they should be protected from price increases.

Andrew

I think the government keeping gas prices low is a bad policy. The biggest problem we face now is global climate change. The more expensive gasoline is, the less people will drive, and thus they will contribute fewer greenhouse gases to the air. Lowering the cost of gas just makes the problem worse.

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Section 1 of 1

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Your professor is teaching a class on economics. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

Doctor Diaz

Our current unit looks at tourism and the benefit it has on a country's economy. Many argue that while tourism can indeed be a money-making endeavor, it can do more harm than good, especially tourism to small, remote places that are not heavily populated. What is your opinion? Should local or national governments promote tourism to remote regions not typically visited by tourists before? Why?

Andrew

Tourism has always been a lucrative business. Improving the economies of these rural regions, especially if those regions are poor, can only have a positive effect. People can have a better quality of life by showcasing their food and traditions to the outside world. It's a chance the people might not get without promotion from the government.

Claire

I don't think governments should promote tourism to remote regions. The people are likely not asking for this kind of industry or for this kind of attention. Instead, governments should develop other means of improving a region's economic situation, like expanding agriculture or other industries. These efforts will have a stronger, more permanent impact on the region than bringing in groups of tourists.

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An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Achebe

Today, we will examine what economists call incentives—the motivations that lead people to make certain choices. Cost is a major category of economic incentives. People tend to change their behavior when a particular choice gets more expensive. Let's discuss an example. Some economists argue that a good way to reduce air pollution is for governments to raise the cost (through taxes or other means) of fuel for cars. Do you agree or disagree with this viewpoint?



Andrew

I think it would be a good idea to raise fuel prices. Making it more expensive to drive cars would cause many people to choose public transportation or use bicycles instead. In my city, they've just added bicycle lanes to all of the major roads. So, it would be easy to give up driving.



Claire

I disagree. Why should individuals be punished with such an added expense in their daily lives? The argument for a consumer fuel tax makes the assumption that cars are the biggest source of air pollution, and we need to question if that's an accurate assumption.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:59 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on economics. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Gupta

We have recently read in our textbook that local or regional governments often need to reduce the amount of money budgeted in some areas in response to economic shortfalls. For instance, a city council may make the difficult decision to spend less on a certain public service for its residents. In your view, in what one or two areas should local or regional governments reduce spending when budget cuts are necessary? Why?



Claire

My city has a lot of parks that require a lot of upkeep. If there's a need to reduce expenses, the city could make changes to the parks that make them less expensive to maintain. For example, grass lawns, which need to be cut weekly, could be replaced with other plant species that do not need to be cut frequently.



Paul

Last time I went to City Hall to take care of some business, I saw a lot of employees standing around and doing nothing. I think the local government may be employing too many workers. It was just an impression I had, but I wonder if this is something that should be reviewed.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:57 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on economics. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Gupta

Automation is a much-discussed topic in economics, one that continues to grow in importance with today's advances in robotics and artificial intelligence, or AI. Robots and AI provide powerful ways to replace human labor by doing work better and faster than people can. Automation can have very positive effects on businesses and the broader economy, but there are disadvantages as well. What do you think? Is the use of automation a positive development

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Paul

I think the use of automation is a positive development. If AI and robots are used instead of human workers, companies will be able to produce many more products than they do now. They can also lower costs, making those products cheaper for people to buy. As a result, everyone will have access to more-affordable products.

Kelly

I worry about the psychological effects on people as AI and robots take over work. I doubt humans will really be happy with ever-greater amounts of leisure time. Many of us derive satisfaction from working and doing our jobs well. In fact, never in human history have we been able to spend large parts of our days labor-free.

Technology (Two Articles)

ETS TOEFL

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to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

In our discussion on the importance of workplace mentoring, we learned that mentoring (training or guiding someone) is typically associated with senior employees—that is, workers who have been at a company for a long time and mentor younger colleagues. However, at some companies, especially those that use innovative technology, younger employees sometimes train or guide senior colleagues. Do you think that it is a good idea for companies to encourage younger employees to mentor senior coworkers? Why or why not?

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Claire

I support the idea of having younger employees mentor senior ones. Technology is developing so rapidly these days, and young people are much more skilled in dealing with technology than older employees are. It's the ideal way for senior employees to learn new digital skills.

Kelly

Claire makes a good point, but technology aside, I do not think that younger employees make good mentors right away. When younger employees join companies, they often lack the experience needed to be fully effective in their roles. They should be mentored by senior coworkers who have achieved a high level of expertise in their work.

Management (Two Articles)

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Your professor is teaching a class on business administration. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Diaz

We've been discussing the importance of hiring and retaining highly skilled employees, but even the best employees may need to periodically update or further develop their work skills. One question facing managers is how much time and money to invest in improving the work skills of their employees. Some managers argue that ongoing employee training is the most important investment a company can make. What are your thoughts on the matter?



Andrew

I don't think that employee training is the most important investment a company can make. The company should be hiring the most skilled workers it can find in the first place. There are so many other unavoidable things that a company needs to spend money on that have to take precedence over training.



Kelly

Employees' leaving their jobs is always a risk, but providing ongoing training and skill development is more likely to make employees want to stay rather than go, in my opinion. When employers pay for training, employees are likely to feel more valued by their employer, and this can only improve the employer-employee relationship.

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Section 1 of 100:09:45  Hide Timer

resource management. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Achebe

This week, we'll be discussing how technological advances are transforming the job market, making some jobs unnecessary. Let's focus on government actions. Suppose the government had to choose between two ways in which to support people whose jobs are no longer needed. The government could either give them enough money to live on until they find new jobs or offer them free job training without giving them money directly. Which of these two solutions do you think is better? Why?



Andrew

I believe that the government should prioritize providing free job training opportunities. Modern training programs are usually costly, which means that many people will not be able to afford them without the government's funding. By participating in training programs, people will develop new, in-demand skills and become more competitive in the job market.



Kelly

Although I agree that having access to free training programs sounds promising, I think the government's first step should be to give people enough money to live on until they find new jobs. This money will go directly into people's pockets and allow them to make their own choices concerning their future.

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Business (Three Articles)

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Section 1 of 1

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Your professor is teaching a class on human resources management. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Doctor Diaz

Our next class will focus on how companies maintain their staffing levels. While it is important for a company to look for new employees to fill open positions, many believe it is equally important for a company to retain the workers it already has on staff. In your opinion, what is the best way for a company to encourage its employees to stay at the company instead of seeking a different job elsewhere?



Paul

I think the best thing a company could do to keep its employees is to create a work environment that employees look forward to going to five days a week. Cramped office spaces or disorderly factory floors are not places I would want to spend a third of my life.



Claire

I see Paul's point. But even more important than a nice workspace is making sure the employees don't feel stuck in their jobs. Companies should offer opportunities for employees to advance their skills so they can get new positions within the company if they want. Employees should feel like they have a goal to work toward.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

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Your professor is teaching a class on business. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

**Dr. Gupta**

We've been talking about the process of starting a new business. One of the most important aspects of the process is staffing—that is, deciding which people to hire. Please discuss the following question: Is it better for new businesses to hire experienced veterans of the industry or to staff the business with younger employees who are right out of university? Why do you think so?

**Claire**

I think a company should staff a business with the most experienced employees possible. If you're starting a new business, you need people around you who know what they are doing and can get the business up to speed fast. Spending time training inexperienced people will slow you down.

**Paul**

I understand what Claire is saying, but if you are starting a new business, you want people who are particularly enthusiastic and energetic. Who better than a recent graduate to bring those qualities to the job? You would be guaranteed an ambitious hard worker.

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:37 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on business. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.

**Dr. Achebe**

Today, we are going to discuss how successful software and tech products are launched and marketed. When companies launch and market these products, early adopters are important. Early adopters are customers who tend to buy the latest products and like to be the first to try out new features and processes. In today's discussion, I would like you to describe at least one advantage or disadvantage of being an early adopter. Please explain why you think this way.

**Andrew**

One obvious disadvantage is that early adopters probably pay a lot more for brand-new technology. When products first come out, they're often quite expensive, but once they've been on the market for a while, the price usually drops. That's why I usually wait to buy new technology.

**Claire**

New tech products might not always be more expensive—sometimes the company will give people a new product at a discount in exchange for trying it out and giving feedback on it. In fact, to me, that's the biggest advantage of being an early adopter—your feedback can guide future improvements to a product. That's a powerful feeling.

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Psychology (Two Articles)

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Help

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:57 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on psychology. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Diaz

This week we talked about how important taking time off from work or school is for people's well-being. Some people believe they get the most benefit when that time off is structured; that is, it involves planning in advance about what will be accomplished on that day. Others believe it is better to enjoy the day with no plan for how to spend it. In this discussion post, please indicate which of those approaches to spending time off from work or school you prefer, and why.



Claire

I find it beneficial to do some advance planning for my free time. I live far away from my family, so when I am getting ready to visit them during a school holiday, I always plan my time off from school very carefully. That way I have enough time to visit with each family member.



Paul

Personally, I prefer not to make any plans for my free time. I go to school, and I have a part-time job, and each week I make a schedule to be sure I can complete both my work and my studies. So when I have time off from work and school, I just want to relax with no plan.

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Writing | Question 2 of 200:09:58 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on educational psychology. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Diaz

Secondary or high school students (ages 14-18) who plan to attend university must begin thinking about what field of study they'll enter. Some students might be directed into certain fields by their parents and teachers. Others prefer to make their own choice based on their own interests and feelings. Do you believe that secondary school students should be allowed to choose their own field of study at university without being guided by parents and teachers? Why?

Why?



Kelly

I think it's a mistake to let students at that age make such an important decision on their own. They usually don't have the wisdom to choose appropriately. The people who know them best—their parents and teachers—will be more objective and give the best guidance.



Andrew

Choosing a field of study, and perhaps a career in that field, based mainly on what others tell you to do seems wrong to me. My parents wanted me to study engineering, but I'm not interested in that; I want to help people learn. I know I'll struggle more financially as a teacher, but I'm sure I'll be happier.

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Marketing (One Article)

Urban Planning (One Article)

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Volume

Help

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Writing | Question 2 of 2

00:09:57 Hide Time

Your professor is teaching a class on urban planning. Write a post responding to the professor's question.

In your response, you should do the following.

- Express and support your opinion.
- Make a contribution to the discussion in your own words.

An effective response will contain at least 100 words.



Dr. Achebe

In the next few weeks, we'll be talking about urban traffic management. Let's begin by discussing one popular idea—creating car-free central zones. Some cities around the world have recently designated their downtown areas as being automobile-free, which means that vehicles are not allowed to enter the city centers. Do you think that more cities should make their central zones car-free? Why or why not?



Claire

I support the idea of establishing car-free central zones because this will result in one important benefit for city residents—it will be better for their health. Instead of driving everywhere, people will be encouraged to walk or cycle more. It would be a great way to incorporate exercise into people's routines.



Paul

It sounds like a good idea, but I'm skeptical. My main concern is that many businesses located in the city centers, such as shops and restaurants, may suffer because the customers will no longer be able to reach those businesses by car. For some customers, if they can't drive, they won't go at all.

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